



The photo "Earthrise" was taken from the Apollo 8 spacecraft on the morning of December 24, 1968.

EARTHRISE

70 A picture, so the saying goes, is worth a thousand words. But in a world in which millions of photographs are taken and uploaded every minute and we are exposed to a daily avalanche of pictures on our computer screens, what is the value of a single image? According to Martin Barnes, Senior Curator of photographs at the Victoria and Albert Museum in London, "Great photographs are like visual poetry. They neatly capture and express a situation or emotion that transcends the everyday." By capturing a single moment and holding it absolutely still, a photograph can convey a powerful idea in a universal language. But more than that, images can transport us to new places and help us see our lives from a different perspective. As National Geographic photographer Aaron Huey says, "Photography has the power to undo your assumptions about the world."

Nowhere is this more clearly illustrated than in "Earthrise," the groundbreaking picture which, though not the first ever photo of the Earth from space, transformed people's attitudes to a world they had taken for granted up to that point. It all started on the morning of December 21, 1968, when the crew of Apollo 8—Frank Borman, Jim Lovell, and Bill Anders—set out for humanity's first manned mission to orbit the moon. With the excitement of lunar exploration, photographs of Earth were not included at all in the official NASA plans. Yet when, on Christmas Eve, and on their fourth orbit, the crew emerged from behind the moon's dark side, they saw in front of them an astounding sight—an exquisite blue sphere hanging in the blackness of space.

"Look at that picture over there. Here's the Earth coming up. Wow! That is pretty!", exclaimed Anders. It is thought that at this point Borman snapped a black-and-white image of the scene. "Hey, don't take that. It's

not scheduled," Anders joked. He then added, "Hand me that roll of color, quick." After a brief scramble to find the film, Anders shot a color photograph. It showed the Earth as a blue planet, partially covered by white swirling clouds and contrasting starkly with the empty backdrop of space and the dead, gray lunar surface, which Borman described as "a vast, lonely, forbidding expanse of nothing." Looking back on the mission, Anders observed, "I was immediately almost overcome by the thought that here we came all this way to the moon, and yet the most significant thing we're seeing is our own home planet." Borman also said that glimpsing Earth was "the most beautiful, heart-catching sight of my life, one that sent a torrent of nostalgia, of sheer homesickness, surging through me."

The true power of photographs lies in what is done with them after they are created. Within just a few months of the shot being taken, millions of people on Earth had seen the picture, which soon became one of the most iconic images of the century. "Earthrise" gave a new perspective on the planet at a time of great social and political unrest. As Borman remarked, "Raging nationalistic interests, famines, wars, pestilences don't show from that distance. From out there, it really is 'one world.'" Moreover, many people credit the birth of the environmental movement and the first Earth Day celebration in 1970, to this view of the planet from outer space—a view that showed its smallness, fragility, and vulnerability. People realized there was no other sanctuary in the solar system, and so they needed to conserve Earth's resources and protect it from pollution and destruction. Lovell concluded, "It was the most beautiful thing there was to see in all the heavens. People down here don't realize what they have."